

[Content | Lite]

User Manual & How-To Guide

Lightweight PHP CMS with news, gallery, admin panel, and browser-based installer

1. Overview

ContentLite is a lightweight, self-hosted PHP content management system. It ships with a news/article module, an image gallery with albums, a browser-based first-run installer, and a password-protected admin panel. It runs on plain PHP and MySQLi, with no framework dependencies.

Key features

- News publishing with a rich-text (TinyMCE) editor and Draft / Published status
- Gallery albums with image upload, editing, sorting, and lightbox viewing
- Browser-based installer with optional database table prefix support
- Shared front-end template with responsive navigation
- Minimal stack: plain PHP + MySQLi, no external framework

Requirements

- PHP 8.0 or higher
- MySQL or MariaDB
- PHP extensions: mysqli, mbstring, dom, fileinfo
- Write access to the project folder if you want the installer to update config.php automatically

2. Installation

ContentLite uses a first-run, browser-based installer, similar to classic WordPress-style setup wizards.

1. Upload the entire project folder to your web server (via FTP, SFTP, or your hosting file manager).
2. Open install.php in your browser, e.g. <https://yourdomain.com/install.php>
3. Fill in your database settings:
 - DB Host — usually localhost (use 127.0.0.1 instead if your host reports a connection error 2002)
 - DB Name — the database ContentLite should use (it will be created automatically if it doesn't exist)
 - DB User and DB Password — credentials with permission to create databases and tables

- Table Prefix (optional) — useful if you're sharing one database across multiple sites, e.g. site1_
4. Leave "Save DB settings to config.php" checked if you want the installer to write the credentials into config.php for you. If config.php isn't writable, you'll need to edit the DB_* constants there manually.
 5. Click "Run installation". The installer will create the database (if needed), create the required tables (cms_content, gallery_albums, gallery_images), and confirm each step with an OK message.
 6. Once installation succeeds, delete install.php from the server, or restrict access to it — leaving it in place is a security risk.

Security: install.php can (re)configure your database connection and, if writable, overwrite config.php. Always remove or lock it down immediately after a successful install.

Default admin login

Username	admin
Password (seed)	change_this_password

Security: Change the default admin password hash in config.php before putting the site into production. Never leave the seed password active on a live site.

3. Logging Into the Admin Panel

7. Go to admin.php in your browser, e.g. <https://yourdomain.com/admin.php>
8. You'll land on the login screen (?action=login) if you aren't already signed in.
9. Enter your admin username and password, then submit the form.
10. On success you're taken to the content overview (the default "list" view).

To log out at any time, use the logout link/action in the admin panel (?action=logout), which ends your session.

4. Managing News & Content

The admin panel's default view is the content overview: a table of all articles with their title, status, and last-updated date.

Create a new article

11. From the content overview, choose the option to add new content (the "new" action).
12. Enter a Title.
13. Write the body using the rich-text editor (TinyMCE). Supported formatting includes headings, bold/italic/underline, lists, tables, blockquotes, code blocks, images, links, and embedded iframes from common providers.
14. Choose a Status: Draft (not shown publicly) or Published (visible on the front end).
15. Save. You'll see a confirmation message and return to the content list.

Edit an article

16. From the content overview, select "Edit" next to the article you want to change.
17. Update the title, content, and/or status.
18. Save your changes.

Delete an article

19. From the content overview, select "Delete" next to the article.
20. Confirm the action. The article is permanently removed.

Note: Only non-empty content is accepted — an article needs a title and either text or an allowed embed (image, video, audio, iframe, etc.) before it can be saved.

5. Managing the Gallery

The gallery is organized into albums; each album holds one or more images.

Create an album

21. Open the Gallery section of the admin panel.
22. Choose to add a new album.
23. Enter a Name and an optional Description.
24. Save to create the album.

Upload images to an album

25. Open the album from the gallery overview.
26. Use the upload option to select one or more image files.
27. Optionally set a title for each image before uploading (otherwise the filename is used).
28. Submit the upload. Each image is validated before being stored.

Allowed formats	JPEG, PNG, GIF, WebP
Maximum file size	5 MB per image

Edit or reorder images

29. Open the album and select "Edit" on an image.
30. Update its title, description, or sort order (a numeric value controlling display order).
31. Save your changes.

Delete albums or images

Deleting an image removes both its database record and the file on the server. Deleting an album removes all of its images (files and records) along with the album itself — this cannot be undone.

Security: Album deletion is permanent and cascades to every image inside it. Make sure you no longer need the images before deleting an album.

6. Front-End Pages

index.php	Public homepage
news.php	Public news listing and individual article pages
gallery.php	Public gallery: album listing and album detail with lightbox viewing
admin.php	Admin panel — content and gallery management (login required)
install.php	Browser-based installer (remove after setup)

Only articles with status Published appear on the public news pages; Draft articles remain visible only inside the admin panel.

7. Configuration & Deployment Notes

- Set `SITE_BASE_URL` correctly in `config.php` so links and assets resolve properly.
- Confirm the upload directory used for gallery images is writable by the web server.
- Remove or lock down `install.php` once setup is complete.
- Replace any placeholder database credentials with your real ones before going live.
- Base database tables are `cms_content`, `gallery_albums`, and `gallery_images`; an optional prefix (set during installation) is applied to all three.

8. Troubleshooting

"Database connection failed" with error 2002 during install

Some shared hosts fail to resolve `localhost` as a socket path. Try entering `127.0.0.1` as the DB Host instead.

Login fails with correct-looking credentials

Confirm the username matches `ADMIN_USER` and that the password matches the hash stored in `ADMIN_PASS_HASH` inside `config.php` — the default seed password only works until it's changed.

Uploaded image is rejected

Check that the file is a JPEG, PNG, GIF, or WebP and is under 5 MB. Other formats and larger files are rejected for security and storage reasons.

Article won't save

Make sure the Title field isn't empty and the content isn't blank — an article needs visible text or at least one allowed embedded element (image, video, audio, or `iframe`).